

The Art of Amōre

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Updating Ovid's "Ars Amatoria"

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Introduction

This book is an introduction to Ovid, a popular poet in Augustan Rome who wrote "Ars Amatoria" in the year 2 BC. In this trilogy he lays out his recommendations for finding and keeping love. In our time we might think of it as a seduction manual, or advice about "game".

He also wrote "Metamorphoses", a 15-book saga about self-transformation, which I have yet to read. My understanding is that it lays out the pantheon of Roman gods — mostly derived from Greek gods, but with a Roman spin.

In a very real sense, our gods are the human emotions, externalized and personified. As such, you could say that Ovid was one of the fathers of psychology; even more than Freud or Jung.

Most English commentaries translate "Ars Amatoria" as "the Art of Love"; but I see this as a loss of fidelity, so I went with "the Art of Amōre".

The English word "love" is so nebulous that it is almost meaningless. There are many types of affection — are we talking about maternal, paternal, fraternal, philia, amore, eros, agapé, anahata, enthios, exstasis?

Amore is typically taken to be the same as the Greek eros; but I feel that amore carries a bit more of a sense of partnership and exclusivity as a couple, while eros can be purely sexual.

To put it in modern terms, when I hear the phrase "friends with benefits" or "dtf", I tend to think of the Greek god Eros; while I feel that the Roman Amor/Cupid might require some sort of exclusivity. If not full monogamy, at least "serial monogamy" or "ethical non-monogamy".

But what do I know? I don't have any direct recall of Augustan Rome or how they used the word amor.

Ovid's advice was bold, witty, and rooted in the gender politics of his time.

Two thousand years later, the potentials of attraction and connection remain constant. The fundamental human need for love hasn't changed; we still need to feel seen and accepted. We still seek and offer intimacy.

However, the world has shifted, and the way we view sexual relationships and intimacy has evolved.

This book re-imagines Ovid's original counsel with contemporary insight. His words appear in quotes, followed by my reinterpretation from a modern perspective.

I can't claim to speak for humanity or modernity as a whole, but I've been around the sun a few times, and learned some principles about love which I hope you find helpful.

Alongside Ovid's ancient wisdom, we will trace what the last two millennia have taught about attraction, desire, autonomy, and mutual pleasure. Not to correct Ovid's message, but to evolve it.

Ovid laid a solid groundwork expressing principles of love as they were known at the time. Much of his advice still holds true, but in the light of modernity, some principles have changed.

Where his observations align with timeless human ways, we honor them. Where the world has shifted, we adapt.

What follows is a conversation across centuries — love's ancient practice, recalibrated for a new age that espouses the values of equality, individuality, and active assent.

My main additions are the modern ideals which emancipate women from the role of "prey or target" to one that values her free agency, and a negotiated collaboration between the sexes. Look for intentional participation — more than passive consent — watch for her enthusiastic assent.

Authors' Messages

Ovid Speaks (2 AD):

"Should any one of the people not know the art of loving, let him read me; and taught by me, let him love.

By art the ships are onward sped by sails and oars; by art are the light chariots, by art is Love, to be guided.

In the chariot and in the flowing reins was Automedon skilled: in the Hæmonian ship of Jason, Tiphys was the pilot.

Me, too, skilled in my craft, has Venus made the guardian of Love. Mother of Love, favour my design.

Me, too, will Love yield; though, with his bow, Cupid should wound my breast.

To this work experience gives rise; listen to a Poet well-versed. The truth will I sing. We will sing of guiltless delights, and of thefts allowed; and in my song there shall be nought that is criminal.

This is my plan; this space shall be marked out by my chariot; this the turning-place to be grazed by my wheels in their full career:

In the first place, endeavour to find out an object which you may desire to love.

The next task after that, is to prevail on the fair by pleasing her.

The third is, for her love to prove of long duration."

Michael Responds (2026):

If you've struggled in love — and who hasn't — may this book open your heart so that attraction moves freely through you, naturally and with ease.

Like navigation, love has its rhythms and principles which can be learned. My intention is to offer a compass to guide us, and star-maps to align us with the foundations of affection.

As with Ovid, I have an artistic lean. My empathic resonance can be deep, although it is sometimes intermittent or misplaced.

Often I'm skilled at emotional resuscitation and spiritual activation, as I have navigated the traumas of my own Scylla and Charybdis, coming out the other side with some hard-won wisdom.

I am not saying that I'm a total expert in all things related to love and sex, but I do have some insights worth sharing.

Take my advice, such as it pleases and benefits you. I offer it with pure intent, with my wish for you to thrive and have all your heart's true desires.

One more thing before we set sail. A single thread runs beneath everything in this book, and it will surface fully near the end: love is not only a social art. It is a spiritual one. The same current that draws two people together across a crowded room is, I believe, the current that draws all things toward wholeness — attraction is gravity wearing a human face. For most of these pages we will keep our feet on the practical ground, walking with Ovid through the arts of approach and conversation and care. But know from the beginning that the road is quietly climbing. In Chapter Fifteen we will stand at the summit and take in the view.

PART ONE

Foundations

CHAPTER ONE

Taking Initiative

Ovid speaks:

"Alas! too great is the confidence of any youth in his own good looks, if he awaits for her to be the first to ask him.

Let the man make the first approaches; let the man use words of entreaty; she will kindly receive his soft entreaties.

To gain your wish, ask; she only wishes to be asked. Tell her the cause and the origin of your desires.

As, forsooth, there is shame in first beginning at any time, so 'tis pleasing to the fair to submit, when the other takes the initiative.

Now is the time come for some conversation: fly afar hence, coy bashfulness, let Chance and Venus befriend the daring. Let your eloquence not be subject to any laws of mine; only make a beginning; of your own accord you will prove fluent."

Someone has to initiate, and yeah, it is usually still expected that the man will do so. This doesn't mean that women shouldn't initiate — in fact they often do, and typically with more subtlety.

But most women still prefer the man to show initiative, because it signals real interest. "My attraction to you is strong enough that I'm willing to risk rejection."

Initiative is also an indicator of confidence. True confidence — not performative bravado — suggests that you have your life together. Confidence is an indicator of social, financial, and sexual competence,

which reflects on your ability to co-operate with others in building value; to gather and share resources for your future family; and to pleasure your partner.

So guys, we are still expected to express our attraction. Don't pussyfoot around; don't hide behind a cover story of platonic friendship. Be honest about sharing your attraction, and risk rejection.

Let your interest be clear. Eye contact that communicates attention. Words that reveal you're engaged with this person specifically, noticing details that make them distinct.

Notice what genuinely attracts you and say so. Not as strategy, but as honest observation. "You have an interesting way of thinking about that." "Your laugh is contagious." "I love how animated you become when you talk about this."

Specific compliments about qualities someone has cultivated — intelligence, humor, passion, craft — resonate more deeply than generic praise about an appearance they were born with.

Clearly ask: "Would you like to go for coffee?" "Do you want to exchange numbers?" "I'd like to see you again." Direct and respectful.

Then actually listen to her response. Is it steeped in enthusiasm, or is there deflection or rejection? Honor her answer even if it isn't what you hoped to hear.

This is the part that trips up many guys because we are taught to be persistent.

If she's hesitant, your willingness to back off a bit may just create the space for her to move toward you without feeling forced or obligated. If you pursue when she is hesitant, you pressurize that space which may otherwise have provided her an opportunity to reconsider.

Equality

We live in an age of increased equality, however it is important to notice the difference between equality of freedoms and equality of outcome.

Equality of freedom boils down to equal application of law and other social structures. That's a fantastic ideal, because it allows people to offer their best to society. Freedom works best when tempered with some degree of empathy and support for those who don't thrive in any of the many social hierarchies.

To what degree? That depends if you are conservative or liberal; legalistic or empathic. It takes both types to build the guard rails of society, and keep us away from tyranny or anarchy.

However, insistence on equality of outcome is a problematic idea. Not only is it difficult to enact, but to seriously try would force people into roles which run counter to their innate preferences, in the attempt to equalize the numbers.

The attempt to equalize outcomes often reflects a subtle bias — usually the expectation that women should want the same things as men.

There are real biological and social differences between the sexes. Apples and oranges are equally delicious, but different. Who entreats the orange to become more apple-like? Who in their right mind thinks that the apple-ness of the Honeycrisp is an imposition on the Valencia?

All forms have their qualities and functions. The more we cultivate freedom of choice, the more aligned people can become with their personal preferences.

CHAPTER TWO

Finding Whom to Love

Ovid advises:

"You who are now coming for the first time to engage as a soldier in a new service: endeavour to find out an object which you may desire to love.

Choose one to whom you may say, 'You alone are pleasing to me.'

She will not come to you gliding through the yielding air; the fair one that suits must be sought with your eyes.

The hunter knows full well where to extend the toils for the deer; full well he knows in what vale dwells the boar gnashing with his teeth. The shrubberies are known to the fowlers. He who holds out the hooks, knows what waters are swam in by many a fish.

You, too, who seek a subject for enduring love, first learn in what spot the fair are to be met with."

Ovid rightly encourages us to be fully present in our own life, so that we may discern who captures our genuine interest.

She isn't going to float down from the sky and appear in your car or bedroom.

"Be not unequally yoked." Pay attention to what attracts you and why. Put yourself in social situations; find people who enjoy the same activities as you and congregate with them.

Connection requires initiative. Look, attend, and be willing to be seen in return.

Ovid adds:

"In your search, I will not bid you give your sails to the wind, nor is a long path to be trodden by you, that you may find her.

Rome will present you damsels as many, and full as fair; so that you will declare, that whatever has been on the earth, she possesses.

Oft in the noisy Forum has the flame been found. But especially at the curving Theatres do you hunt for prey: these places are even yet more fruitful for your desires.

So rush the best-dressed women to the thronged spectacles; a multitude that oft has kept my judgment in suspense. They come to see, they come that they themselves may be seen."

Density creates possibility. You don't need to travel far, especially if you live in a major metropolitan center. There will be so many people who please your eye that it may be difficult to choose. More than you could meet in a lifetime.

So you must be discerning. The heart knows what it wants; it will guide your eyes before your brain catches up.

If you allow it, your heart will point to those of whom you may wonder: "Is she angel or goddess?"

Be aware of love at first sight. Better still, be sensitive to the subtle energy of love at first glance. Find someone whose presence causes your heart to blossom and your whole being to incandesce. This can be frightening because it requires an uncommon openness and confidence.

Sense those who cause your heart to weep. Those who you might call "Wife from another life."

Shared experiences create natural openings for attraction. Concerts, theater, events — you're both present for the same reason, which gives you common ground. The experience itself does half the work by

lowering social barriers and providing easy conversation starters.

Think about where your tribe congregates. Bookstores for readers. Climbing gyms for adventurers. Art openings for the creative.

Go where you genuinely want to be, and you'll naturally find yourself among compatible people. Cities, universities, festivals, conferences — wherever people gather with shared purpose, connections form more easily.

One reason that people attend social spaces is to be social. Almost everyone present is potentially open to attraction, and many seek connection. This is simply human nature — don't feel that your social and sexual instincts are something to hide.

Create opportunities for natural proximity. Sit nearby at the coffee shop. Stand where conversation can flow. Position yourself where interaction can happen organically, but don't force it.

Practice speaking with strangers of both sexes in public. Learn to be sensitive to the ebb and flow of conversation and attraction. This is a skill that can be trained.

If you want to be interesting, be interested.

Attraction is largely the fragrance of a life being genuinely lived. A man who paints, climbs, reads, gardens, builds — who is visibly in love with some corner of the world — carries a quality of aliveness that no pickup line can counterfeit. People orient toward light. Cultivate your interests for their own sake, and attraction arrives as a side effect.

Your interests are also your map. They tell you where your people gather, they hand you conversation that costs nothing to start, and they let a stranger see the true shape of you within the first five minutes. "What have you been obsessed with lately?" is a better opener than any scripted line, because you actually want to know the answer — and because you have an answer of your own.

One caution: don't curate hobbies as bait. An interest pursued for display goes dead in your hands, and people can smell the difference between a passion and a prop. Feed what genuinely fascinates you. The right person will be drawn to the heat of it.

CHAPTER THREE

Persistence and Authenticity

Ovid recommends:

"Now be it your part stealthily to captivate her affection by attentions; just as the shelving bank is encroached on by the flowing stream. Persist in your design. In time the stubborn oxen come beneath the ploughs: in time the steeds are taught to submit to the flowing reins.

What is there harder than stone? What more yielding than water? Yet hard stones are hollowed out by yielding water. Only persist, and in time you will overcome Penelope herself."

"You must act the lover, and wounds must be feigned in your words. Hence let confidence be sought by you, by means of any contrivances whatever.

And 'tis no hard matter to be believed. Yet often, he that pretends to love, begins in reality: full oft he becomes that which in the beginning he feigned to be."

Careful here — this is perhaps Ovid's worst advice.

It is true that women sometimes play "hard to get" in order to test whether your interest is fleeting or sustained. And it is true that familiarity may cultivate empathy over time.

But repeated pursuit of someone who shows disinterest creates discomfort, not desire. Trying to wear down her resistance over time is stalking, not courting.

Express clear interest once; perhaps twice if circumstances seem genuinely complicated. Then rein in your emotions and redirect your attention.

In fact, sometimes pulling back is exactly what she needs you to do, so that she can move toward you without too much headwind.

But forced or manufactured interest wastes everyone's energy and prevents real connections from forming. Be genuinely interested or move on.

Legitimate attraction has a frequency that can't be faked well or sustained long. If you're drawn to someone, let that show naturally through authentic interest, curiosity, and empathy.

If someone is interested but timing is wrong, they know where to find you. Let people come toward you as much as you move toward them.

CHAPTER FOUR

Confidence and Attitude

Ovid encourages:

"Lo! I utter a prophecy; thou wilt conquer! First of all, let a confidence enter your mind, that all women may be won; you will win them; do you only lay your toils.

Sooner would the birds be silent in spring, the grasshoppers in summer, sooner would the Mænalían dog turn its back upon the hare, than the fair, attentively courted, would resist the youth.

Come then, and doubt not that you can conquer all the fair: out of so many, there will be hardly one to deny you.

She, however, will wish you to believe, so far as you can, that she is reluctant. What they yield, and what they refuse, still are they glad to be asked for."

Begin with the knowledge that connection is possible. Most people are open to attraction when conditions align — mutual interest, good timing, compatible energy.

Instead of playing to win the game, play for the sake of the game. Play so that the game wins.

Approach with the expectation that genuine attention might be reciprocated, while understanding that it might not be.

If your attention is welcomed, you win; if your attention is rejected, you learn. Both outcomes are a win, therefore be confident.

The universe is listening to your attitude and aches to give you more of what you bring to it.

Look at the root of the word: *con fidere* — with faith. Confidence was never meant to be a verdict about yourself, some certified rating of your worth that you must defend in every interaction. It is a posture of trust: trust in the process, trust that honest interest honestly expressed will find its level, trust that a "no" reveals a mismatch rather than a deficiency.

This is why real confidence and real humility turn out to be the same posture seen from two sides. The man with nothing to prove has everything to share. He can approach without armor, be declined without wound, and delight in the encounter either way. Nothing repels like need; nothing attracts like a man at ease in his own life, offering rather than asking.

So walk in with faith — not the faith that she will say yes, but the faith that you will be fine either way. That is the confidence Ovid was pointing at, underneath the bravado of his conquering talk. Not the certainty of victory. The freedom from needing one.

PART TWO

Attention, Proximity, Contact

CHAPTER FIVE

Proximity, Consent, and Assent

Ovid instructs:

"In her shoulders she will bring something for you to be spectator of. Her you may gaze upon, her you may admire.

Be not tired of praising either her face or her hair; her taper fingers too, and her small foot. The praise of their beauty pleases even the chaste.

Much may you say by your brows, much by your gestures."

She wants you to appreciate her. Her shoulders don't carry that weight for nothing. Breasts are a powerful indicator of fertility, and she knows it.

But be sensitive to her vibe; you have to connect with her heart first.

If you aren't connected at the heart level, she'll be creeped out by you looking at her body; but if you are connected, she'll want you to appreciate her clothing, face and body. She dresses and postures to invite interest. But your attention has to be organic and natural. Pro tip: see her as a verb rather than as a noun.

When you are both emotionally attuned, hearts connect through eyes. Your attention itself becomes a compliment.

Non-verbal communication is the larger component of conversation. Eye contact held a moment longer than necessary. A genuine and shared smile. Noticing the same thing and sharing a reaction.

Small exchanges that test for mutual interest without the need for words.

The ultimate non-verbal communication is energetic attraction. There are ways of being in one's body that allow a person to soften the self-other boundary. Our mind is about 10% mirror neurons — more in some people, less in others. There are ways of standing in that hall of mirrors which lessen our attachment to the local narrative self. This allows us to em-path and en-train with other selves.

Eros and Amore

Eros sparks our arousal, and amore inflates our affection.

I want more than consent. I want your conscious, willing assent. I want to feel your desire pouring out of your heart like a green light. I want your amoré and your eros. And I want you to be leaning into me as much as I'm leaning into you.

When she does, when you are looking at each other in amore, when you are connected at the heart — only then look at her neck and her collarbone.

CHAPTER SIX

Empathy and the Brighteyes

Ovid left no text for this chapter — as far as I know, he never wrote about empathy. So allow me a personal interlude here: not commentary on the ancient poet, but a field report from the empath's side of love.

Not everyone is an empath. Many people are oriented around a more dualistic frame of reference — legality, equality, competition. However, I believe that some of the deeper levels of love can only be experienced by two empaths.

When I encounter someone who I now call a Brighteyes, our first glance is distinguished by ease and radiance. Like attracting like; our eyes are drawn together across the room.

At the next level, the world melts around us like the Cheshire Cat. Our hearts open through our eyes, like a fibre-optic live stream, and we flow back and forth into each other's perspective. Our hearts connecting, our minds reflecting, our deeper identity reaching out across the void to feel ourselves as each other.

If you're reaching these levels of her conscious participation — green light! But if you aren't progressing, back off and see if she comes after you.

Because she might be attracted to you by curiosity, especially if you have made something of your life. That doesn't necessarily mean she wants to be sexual with you. But it might; because the attraction of curiosity can morph into the attraction of eros.

Not every heart loves at the same range, and not every reader will recognize the experience I've just described. That's fine. Empathy comes in different radii — some people attune person-to-person, some to the family, the tribe, the whole living world. If this chapter reads like a postcard from a country you've never visited, take from it only this: some connections happen at depths that technique cannot reach. Presence can.

There is far more to say about the empath's path — the gifts, the hazards, the vampires who feed on open hearts — than one interlude can hold. I've written a full book on it: *Radiant Sensitivity: The Power of Empathy*. Consider this chapter its embassy.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Monogamy and Exclusivity

Ovid observes:

*"There you will find what you may love, what you may trifle with,
both what you may once touch, and what you may wish to keep.*

And let her not be seated long without you in the curving Theatre.

*Look, too, behind, who shall be sitting behind you, that he may not
press her tender back with his knee against it."*

Whether you desire a fling or you seek a long-term relationship, there is an aspect of exclusivity to your attraction. Even if you're only together for a day, it excludes the rest of humanity.

Here, Ovid would probably say that he is defending his catch against another predator. And fair enough — if someone starts putting the moves on your partner, you're probably going to assert the boundaries of your couplehood. In fact, the failure of either sex to defend the relationship would feel like abandonment and betrayal.

But generally these days we consider that both partners actively contribute to and shape the relationship, rather than the hunter/prey paradigm.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Eloquence and Cultivation

Ovid advises:

"Youths of Rome: Learn, I recommend you, the liberal arts.

Not only that you may defend the trembling accused. Both the public, and the grave judge, and the silent Senate, as well as the fair, conquered by your eloquence, shall extend their hands.

But let your power lie concealed: and do not be eloquent at the first. Who, but one bereft of sense, would declaim before a charming mistress?

(When writing) Let your letters avoid difficult words. Full oft has a letter proved a powerful cause for hatred. Let your language be intelligible, and your words the usual ones; but pleasing, so that you may seem to be speaking in person."

Cultivate yourself; build knowledge, opinions, skills, and passions. Becoming genuinely interested in a wide variety of topics will make you broadly interesting.

But don't perform your cultivation. Intelligence and curiosity attract when they are genuine, but alienate when they are performative; contrived for display.

Ask questions. Listen deeply. Build on what the other person shares. Good conversation is collaborative.

When replying to a text, bounce off the existing thread. If someone replies to an ongoing thread with "Hi, hru", or even with something more familiar

like "How's it going?", it pushes the conversation back to square one.

Educate yourself, learn to speak and write. But talk like a human. Skip rehearsed lines and performative eloquence. If you love a particularly wise quote, or if you are moved by a verse of poetry, recite it with the depth of passion that originally drew you to it.

Speak directly, with warmth and genuine curiosity. Be present in the conversation that is actually happening.

CHAPTER NINE

Wine

Ovid says:

"Lo! Bacchus calls his own Poet: he too, aids those who love.

Here, in secret discourse, you may say to her many a free word, which she may understand is addressed to her; and you may trace out short compliments with a little wine, so that she may read on the table that she is your favorite; and look on her eyes with eyes that confess your flame; the silent features often have both words and expression.

Therefore, when the gifts of Bacchus placed before you fall to your lot, and the fair one shall be a sharer in the convivial couch; pray both to father Nyctelius, and his nocturnal rites, that they will bid the wine not to take effect on your head.

A sure rule for drinking shall be given you by me: let both your mind and your feet ever observe their duty. Especially avoid quarrels stimulated by wine, and hands too ready for savage warfare."

Social lubricants can ease nervousness, but don't get stumbling drunk, or fighting drunk. A drink or two may ease tensions; but more than that obscures connection.

Stay present. You want to remember this conversation, and so does she.

CHAPTER TEN

Physical Escalation

Ovid suggests:

"But when, the tables removed, the guests shall be going, mix in the throng: and quietly stealing up to her as she walks, twitch her side with your fingers; and touch her foot with your foot."

Physical escalation should be gradual and mutual. Start with socially acceptable touch — a hand on the shoulder while laughing, a brief touch on the arm. Notice the response. Do they lean in or pull back? Reciprocate or freeze? Let them initiate contact too. If all physical touch flows one direction, pause. As comfort grows mutually, intimacy can deepen naturally.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Grooming

Ovid advises:

"But let neatness please you; let your body be bronzed on the Plain of Mars: let your robe be well-fitting, and without a spot. Let your tongue, too, not be clammy; your teeth free from yellowness; and let not your foot wallop about, losing itself in the shoe down at heel.

Let not the cutting shockingly disfigure your hair bolt upright; let your locks, let your beard be trimmed by a skilful hand. Let your nails, too, not be jagged, and let them be without dirt; and let no hairs project from the cavities of your nostrils. And let not the breath of your ill-smelling mouth be offensive; and let not the husband and the father of the flock offend the nostrils.

The rest, allow the luxurious fair to do; and any man that perchance disgracefully seeks to attract another."

Don't over-engineer your appearance, but basic care matters. Clean clothes that fit. Good hygiene. Physical fitness — not for appearance but for how it makes you feel in your body. This is self-respect made visible.

Find your own style — the version of yourself which you feel most confident inhabiting — and show up as that. Present yourself well, but also stay true to your own identity.

And contrary to Ovid, if you want to peacock, go for it; there will be those who like it. Likewise, if you are attracted to the same sex, it's no one else's business in many modern cultures.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Direct and Indirect Connection

Ovid suggests:

*"But first, be it your care to make acquaintance with the handmaid
of the fair one to be courted; she can render your access easy."*

Don't piss off her friends, but if you need intermediaries and stratagems to gain someone's attention, you're overcomplicating it.

Genuine connection happens directly. If someone is interested, they'll make themselves accessible. If they're not, workarounds don't create desire.

PART THREE

Deepening Connection

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Understanding Differences

Ovid observes:

"There are various dispositions in the fair; treat these thousand dispositions in a thousand different ways. The same soil does not produce everything; one suits the vine, another the olive; in this, corn springs up vigorously.

There are as many characters in these various dispositions, as there are forms in the world; the man that is wise, will adapt himself to these innumerable characters.

And as at one moment Proteus will make himself flow in running water; and now will be a lion, now a tree, now a shaggy goat."

Ovid asserts that passion runs hotter in women's nature, but I'd hesitate to go quite that far.

If you take a random man and a random woman, something like 60% of the time, the woman will be the more agreeable of the two. On average, women tend to prioritize people; while men focus more on things and systems. I can see how one could equate that with a differential of passion, but I don't think it maps directly.

There are significant differences between the sexes, however a wider difference exists between individuals within either sex. Men and women are different, but we aren't THAT different. In some of the most important ways, we are the same across genders.

Attraction exists in everyone, manifesting differently across individuals. Arousal patterns are personal. Some experience spontaneous attraction

and desire; others respond to context or to iterated connections over time.

The differences aren't right or wrong — they are more like flowers and seeds, or liberal and conservative, yin and yang. So know yourself, and stay curious about others. Not everyone is a match for you, and that's ok.

Pleasure Response

One area where a major difference exists between the sexes is in the capacity for sexual pleasure.

In *Metamorphoses* Book 3, Tiresias is the only human to have lived as both a man and a woman. When asked by Jupiter and Juno who enjoys sex more, he famously sides with Jupiter, stating that women experience nine-tenths of the pleasure, while men experience only one-tenth.

In Ovid's time, this was used as a "cautionary tale" to justify male control over "insatiable" women. Even recently, in the Victorian age, the female body's superior capacity for ecstasy was pathologized as hysteria.

There is no doubt that women have a far greater ability than men to experience rolling, almost continuous pleasure. This should be considered a biological celebration. If you question this, I refer you to my first book "100 Orgasms an Hour: Exploring Female Ecstasy".

People are different. What creates connection with one person may not work with another. Stay curious and aware, rather than formulaic. Learn what matters to the specific person in front of you.

Flexibility matters. The ability to meet someone where they are, to match their energy and communication style, creates rapport. This means finding the aspects of yourself that resonate with them, not becoming someone else entirely.

Read the room; match the energy present. If someone seems nervous, rushing forward creates distance. If someone is reserved, intensity will overwhelm. Attunement — sensing where they are and meeting them there — builds trust and safety.

PART FOUR

Sustainable Desire

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Reciprocity

Ovid warns:

"A woman finds contrivances, by means of which to plunder the riches of the eager lover."

Here Ovid seems to think that most women are gold-diggers. And to be fair, some are — but you can usually sniff out the vibe of a user pretty quickly.

Healthy relationships involve mutual investment. Both people contribute time, attention, vulnerability, resources. If the flow is entirely one-directional — always one person pursuing, planning, financing, accommodating — address the issue head-on. Desire thrives in reciprocity.

What does reciprocity actually look like in practice? Not a fifty-fifty spreadsheet — love keeps no clean books, and trying to force it into one kills the thing being measured. It looks like alternation. Sometimes she plans the evening; sometimes you do. Sometimes you carry the conversation; sometimes she carries you. Both people initiate — dates, conversations, repair after a quarrel, desire itself. Both people ask questions and both people answer them. Over any given week the ledger may tilt wildly; over a season, it evens. What matters is not the arithmetic but the direction of intention: two people each actively reaching toward the other, rather than one reaching and one merely permitting.

Reciprocity is less a transaction than a current. When your investment is received gracefully, it increases your partner's capacity to invest in return — her attention feeds your generosity feeds her warmth feeds your

courage. Love given and returned doesn't just balance; it compounds. This is why reciprocal couples seem to run on some private energy source. They do. They've closed the circuit.

And when it breaks down? Watch the bookkeeping. Imbalance rarely announces itself; it shows up first as a quiet drift in the categories — your time slowly re-filed as "ours," their time protected as "theirs," shared burdens migrating onto your side of the ledger while their preferences become common law. Picture a needle on a dial that always comes to rest at two o'clock, in their favor. Push it back toward mere one o'clock — still their advantage — and they genuinely feel robbed: "How can you be so unfair?" If that pattern sounds familiar, name it early and plainly: observation, not accusation. "I've noticed I've planned our last six evenings. I'd love for you to plan the next one." A partner who cares will hear it and correct course, usually with some embarrassment. A partner who hears it as an attack — repeatedly, after gentle repetition — is telling you something important about the scale they are using, and you should believe them. (I explore this pattern in depth in *Radiant Sensitivity*, in a chapter called *The Ledger*.)

Reciprocity is not romance's accounting department. It is the ecology desire needs to stay alive. Attraction can survive almost anything except the slow discovery that you are the only one tending the garden.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Spirituality and Morality

Ovid reflects:

"'Tis expedient that there should be Gods; and as it is expedient, let us believe them to exist. Let frankincense and wine be presented on their ancient altars. No repose, free from care and similar to sleep, possesses them; live in innocence, for a Divinity is ever present. Restore the pledge; let piety observe her duties; be there no fraud; keep your hands free from bloodshed."

The true testament of character is how you act when no one is watching. When you are alone, act as if the universe is watching.

Ovid is being a pragmatist here — believe in the gods because belief is useful. I want to push one step further, because I think he stumbled onto something truer than he knew. "A Divinity is ever present" is not a useful fiction. It is a plain description of the situation, once you learn how to look.

In the Bhagavad Gita, Krishna offers the deepest formulation I know: "I am the knower. I am the field of the known. I am the act of knowing." Subject, object, and the living dynamic between them — all three are faces of the Divine. Now translate that into the grammar of love: I am the lover. I am the beloved. I am the loving itself. When you look into your partner's eyes, you are not a profane creature peering at another profane creature across a gap of dead space. You are the sacred beholding the sacred, by means of the sacred. The self was never an obstacle to the holy. It is one of its three faces.

This is why love feels the way it feels — like something larger moving through two people who have agreed to stop obstructing it.

The Pulse

Everything alive oscillates. The heart contracts and releases; the lungs fill and empty; and the self, too, has its systole and diastole. We contract into noun-ness — the fully localized "me," dense, distinct, defended. And we expand into verb-ness — the boundaries softening, the self dissolving outward into connection, into wholeness. Neither pole is the goal. The oscillation is the life force itself.

The old symbol for this is the Star of David: one triangle descending, spirit pouring into form; one triangle ascending, form reaching back toward spirit; the two interlocked in a single figure. And the crossing point — the place in the human body where descent and ascent meet — is the heart. The traditions call it Anahata. Lovers know it by feel.

Love, at the energetic level, is two people learning to breathe this pulse together. Coming fully into yourself so that you have a self to give; dissolving toward the other so that the gift can be received; returning to yourself again. Contraction, expansion, contraction. Couples who lose the rhythm get stuck at one pole — fused into a single anxious blob, or armored into two lonely fortresses. Couples who find it can hold both intimacy and individuality, because they are not choosing between the poles. They are the pulse.

The Body as Doorway

Now the thread I promised at the beginning of this book.

Most spiritual traditions, sensing that there is a doorway out of the small narrated self, gave the same unfortunate instruction: push the body away. Fast, renounce, mortify, transcend. As if the flesh were the obstacle.

I have come to the opposite conviction: the doorway runs through the body. Not past it. Not despite it.

Consider what actually happens in deep lovemaking between two people connected at the heart. The inner narrator — that tireless commentator who evaluates, compares, worries, and keeps the story of "me" running — grows quiet. Not through stillness, as in meditation, but through saturation: the signal of shared presence becomes so complete that there is no bandwidth left for narration. Two people stop being nouns to each other. What remains is the verb — the loving, with no separate lover or beloved left to observe it. In the flesh, entirely; yet not of the flesh, because what is revealed is not the body. It is what the body was always carrying.

The old phrase for this is sacred sexuality, and it deserves rescue from both the prudes who deny it and the merchants who cheapen it. Eros, honored consciously between two willing hearts, is a legitimate contemplative path — as capable of hushing the tumult of the self as any monastery, and considerably warmer. (Readers who wish to walk further down this particular road will find the full map in my Polygasm series, beginning with Fountain of Youth. Here it is enough to name the door.)

Two Wings

The Indian traditions speak of jnana and bhakti — the path of knowledge and the path of devotion — and treat them as two wings of the same bird. A bird with one wing circles; with both, it flies.

Apply this to your beloved. Jnana: study her. Learn her history, her patterns, her tender places, what her silences mean, how her courage works. Bhakti: adore her. Let your knowing be warmed by devotion, or it becomes surveillance; let your devotion be informed by knowledge, or it becomes projection — worship of a portrait you painted yourself. Know what you love and love what you know. Two wings. One bird. That is the whole method.

No Stranger

And morality? Ovid gives us rules: restore the pledge, no fraud, clean hands. Rules are the training wheels of goodness, and we need them. But there is a stage past rules.

Guru Nanak said it in five words: "No one is a stranger to me." Not "I am kind to strangers" — the category itself has collapsed. When you have seen, even once, that the knower and the known are the same light, ethics stops being a code you obey and becomes a fact you can't unsee. You keep your hands clean for the same reason you don't punch your own face.

Your beloved is the nearest place where the stranger-line dissolves — the first "other" who becomes not-other. Practice there. The circle widens on its own.

So yes: live in innocence, for a Divinity is ever present. In her. In you. And in the loving that moves between.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Duration and Ongoing Care

Ovid concludes:

"The third task after that, is for her love to prove of long duration."

Sustained desire requires ongoing attention. The work doesn't end when connection is established — it evolves. Keep discovering each other. Make space for growth and change. Prioritize mutual pleasure. Communicate as desires shift. Choose each other actively and repeatedly, not just once.

Notice what Ovid did here. He gave the finding of love one book and the winning of love another — but for the keeping of love, the longest and hardest art, he left mostly a heading. Two thousand years of romances, sonnets, and love songs have repeated his emphasis: endless art about the chase, almost none about the decade after. So we inherit a strange education — expert in beginnings, illiterate in middles.

The first correction is this: duration is not preservation. You are not trying to keep the love you had in the first month, embalmed and displayed. That love was between two people who no longer exist. The art of duration is the art of continuously falling in love with the person your partner is becoming — remaining curious about someone you could easily mistake for fully known. The gardener's stance, not the museum curator's. Nothing in a garden stays; everything in a garden, tended, returns.

The second correction concerns happiness itself. Early love runs on justification — she is so beautiful, he is so attentive, everything confirms the choice. Then daily life arrives, and the confirmations thin out, and many people conclude the love has died. It hasn't. The subsidy has ended.

What's asked of you next is what I call unjustified happiness: instead of waiting for your partner to be perfect enough to justify your joy, you learn to see the perfection already present in each imperfect moment of them — the crooked smile, the tired Tuesday, the whole flawed miracle of a person who keeps showing up. Stop waiting for the world to justify your happiness, and the marriage stops being a courtroom. It becomes a home.

The rest is small arts, practiced daily: the question asked with real curiosity, the thanks said out loud, the hand reached for without occasion, the repair attempted quickly after the quarrel, the desire expressed plainly rather than hinted. None of it is grand. All of it is the actual substance of a long love. Grand gestures are punctuation; this is the prose.

Which brings us to the final chapter — the one Ovid never wrote.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Two Dialects, One Tongue

Ovid taught seduction. He taught the glance held for a beat too long, the letter slipped beneath the door, the calculated absence that makes the heart grow restless. He was brilliant at it. He was also, in the end, exiled for it — and perhaps he knew why.

What he never wrote was the chapter after the game of conquest. What happens when the game is over and two people are simply standing in a room together, wanting to be loved? He had no map for that. Neither, for two thousand years, have most of us.

This is that chapter.

I. The Longing Beneath the Longing

Strip away the courtship rituals — the flowers, the texts, the carefully chosen restaurants — and you find, in every human being who has ever loved, two nearly identical fears: the fear of not being seen, and the fear of not being enough.

She lies awake wondering if he truly knows her — not the version of her that laughs easily at parties, but the one who is sometimes terrified, sometimes furious, sometimes breathtakingly tender for no reason she can name.

He lies awake wondering if she actually wants him — not as a provider, not as a useful presence, but as this specific man, irreplaceable, chosen again this morning on purpose.

Same fear. Different dialect.

This is where most lovers miss each other entirely. Not from lack of love — there is often enormous love — but from speaking fluently in their own dialect and assuming the other speaks it too. She offers him what she would want: conversation, attentiveness, emotional presence. He offers her what he would want: loyalty, physical closeness, the implicit statement of his desire. Each gift lands slightly wrong. Each person feels, quietly, unseen.

Ovid wrote three books about the art of love. He did not write this.

II. What Makes Her Feel Cherished

She wants to be known.

Not admired — though she will accept admiration. Not desired — though desire matters enormously. Known. There is a specific quality of attention that a woman experiences as love, and it has this character: you are paying attention to her interior life. You remember what she said last Tuesday about her mother. You notice when she goes quiet in a particular way. You ask the follow-up question. You treat her inner world as a place worth visiting, worth learning, worth returning to.

This is why women so often say, of the men who have made them feel most loved: "He really listened." They do not mean he was silent while she talked. They mean he was genuinely curious — that her thoughts and feelings registered as interesting to him, worthy of engagement, worth caring about.

The second thing: she wants to be chosen. Deliberately. Repeatedly. Not chosen once at the altar or in the moment of first passion, but chosen today — this specific Tuesday, when she is tired and not particularly radiant and the house is a mess. She wants evidence that if he were deciding again right now, he would choose her. A woman who feels this is fearless. A woman who is uncertain of it spends enormous energy managing the uncertainty, and that energy is no longer available for love.

The third: she wants to be wanted as a full person, not a collection of functions. Wanted for her mind, her humor, her particular way of seeing the world — not only for her body, not only for her domestic presence, not only for her emotional labor. When a man engages with all of her — when he is as interested in what she thinks as in how she looks — something opens in her that cannot be forced open any other way.

This is not complicated. It is, however, easy to forget in the accumulated dailiness of a long love.

III. What Makes Him Feel Cherished

He wants to be trusted.

This is the one that gets missed most often, because it looks from the outside like ego — like a man wanting to be in charge, wanting to be right, wanting dominance. That is a corruption of the real thing. The real thing is simpler and more vulnerable: a man feels loved when the person he loves trusts him. Trusts his judgment. Trusts his intentions. Trusts that when he says he will handle something, she believes him. Trusts that his effort counts even when the outcome is imperfect.

A man who is chronically second-guessed by the person he loves experiences this not as caution but as a verdict: you are not enough. And he will either collapse under that verdict or harden against it. Neither is useful to love.

The second thing: he wants to be wanted. Specifically, physically wanted — and this requires a brief moment of honesty that polite conversation usually avoids. For many men, physical desire is the primary language in which "you are acceptable to me" is spoken. When she initiates, when she makes clear that she wants him — not as a concession, not as a transaction, but from genuine appetite — something settles in him that words cannot quite reach. He feels, at a level beneath language, that he has not been found deficient. That he is enough. That he is, in fact, exactly right.

This is not about frequency. It is about the quality of being wanted.

The third: he wants specific admiration. Not flattery — men are remarkably good at detecting the difference. He wants to be seen doing something well and have that witnessed by someone whose opinion matters to him. The project he finished, the way he handled a hard conversation, the meal he cooked, the thing he built. Noticed. Named. Appreciated with enough specificity that he knows she actually saw it, not just said something kind.

This, too, is not complicated. It is also easy to forget.

IV. The Bridge

She wants to be known. He wants to be trusted.

Read those twice. They are not opposites. They are not even in tension. They are the same longing — for safety, for acceptance, for the specific relief of being with another person and not having to perform — expressed in the two dialects that centuries of different socialization has produced for each sex.

The bridge between them is not compromise. It is not one person abandoning their dialect and learning to speak the other's exclusively. The bridge is the willingness to become bilingual — to learn that your partner's way of needing love is not a criticism of yours, is not wrong, is not a manipulation or a demand. It is simply the shape that love takes in them.

When she tells him, in elaborate detail, about a difficult conversation she had with a colleague, she is not looking for a solution. She is inviting him into her interior world. She is trusting him with it. If he can receive that — not fix it; receive it — she will feel more known than a dozen grand gestures could achieve.

When he falls silent after something goes wrong and needs twenty minutes before he can talk, he is not withdrawing from her. He is processing. He is, in his own way, trying to bring his best self back to the

surface before he speaks. If she can trust that silence — not fill it with anxiety, not read it as rejection — he will return more fully than if she had pursued him into it.

These are small things. They are also the entire thing.

V. What Ovid Left Out

Ovid's great subject was desire in pursuit. The charged approach, the witty letter, the strategic sigh. He was a poet of beginnings — of the electric gap before contact.

He did not write about the long middle. The years. The way love, if it survives at all, must transform from the vertigo of pursuit into something that can bear the weight of an ordinary Tuesday. He did not write about what it means to keep choosing someone — not because the chemistry is surging, but because you know them. Because they are yours and you are theirs and that is a thing you have both decided, quietly, again and again.

He did not write about collaborative love. About the particular joy of building something together — a life, a home, a shared language of private jokes and shorthand and the way you both know, without speaking, which one of you needs to leave the party first. About the way two people who have learned each other's dialects become, over time, something neither could have been alone.

He did not write about reciprocity — the way that love, given generously and received gracefully, multiplies. That when she feels truly known, she becomes more able to admire him. That when he feels truly trusted, he becomes more able to attend to her. That this is not a transaction but a current — each gift increasing the capacity of the other to give.

This is the art Ovid left for someone else to write.

VI. The Practice

None of this is theoretical. It lives in the specific, the daily, the ordinary moment that is easy to rush past.

Ask the question you already know the answer to, because she wants to tell you herself. Notice the thing he did and name it out loud. Reach for her hand not because anything particular is happening but because you are glad she is there. Let him know, with the particular directness that reaches past his defenses, that you want him — not generally, not eventually — now.

Say the thing you have been meaning to say. Not the grand declaration — those have their place but they are easy, in a way. The harder, more sustaining thing: the specific true sentence. "I love the way you think about this." "I felt proud of you in that moment." "I'm glad it's you."

These are the arts. They are not less sophisticated than Ovid's — they are more. They require not cleverness but attention. Not strategy but presence. Not the performance of love but its actual practice.

Amōre, at its root, does not mean desire. It means love — the thing you do, the thing you build, the thing you choose to keep building long after the first fire has settled into something warmer and more sustaining than fire.

That is what this book has been about. That is what Ovid, brilliant and exiled and human, did not quite get to.

We have two thousand years of excuse.

We can do better now.

Closing Reflection

Ovid wrote for his world — strict gender roles, limited agency, seduction as conquest. We write for ours — more freedom, more complexity, more responsibility. The art of amore now centers on creating conditions where two people genuinely choose each other. Where desire flows both directions. Where pleasure is mutual and communication is clear.

The foundations remain: develop yourself, pay attention, show courage and interest. The expression evolves with each generation; hopefully toward authenticity, empathy, and collaboration.

About the Authors

Publius Ovidius Naso was born in Sulmona (now Sulmona, Italy) in 43 BCE and died in exile in Tomis (now Constanța, Romania) in 17 or 18 CE. He lived during a period known as the Augustan Age, renowned for its poetry, literature, and arts. His most famous works include "Metamorphoses," "Ars Amatoria," and "Tristia." He was exiled by Emperor Augustus for reasons that remain mysterious, though it likely involved the scandalous nature of his writings.

Michael Sawyer was born in 1963 in British Columbia, Canada. After outgrowing his parents' religion, he explored various philosophies and spiritual traditions: Carl Jung, Sri Aurobindo, Sri Ramakrishna, and many others. In his early twenties, he found a spiritual mentor who introduced him to an Indian Guru. As an aspirant, he learned to open the heart chakra wide in meditation and experienced transfiguration.

He has delved the depths of the beautiful Bahá'í Faith, been initiated into the Dao, fallen in love with Nike/Victoria/Regina, and frequently takes shamanic photographs of Gaia.

He lives in Drumheller, Alberta, with his wife and son.

His previous book, "100 Orgasms an Hour: Exploring Female Ecstasy," is available on Amazon.